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Ministry Resources Hub

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Lesson 2. Person of Peace

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Lesson 2. Person of Peace

I. INTRODUCTION: WHAT IS A PERSON OF PEACE?

- A. **Gateway to Community:** A Person of Peace is someone open to the Gospel, influential within their community, and willing to facilitate the spread of the message to their social network. This individual acts as a gateway to their community, often paving the way for the message to reach a wider group of people.
- B. **Biblical Example:** Jesus instructed His disciples to find and stay with a Person of Peace when He sent them out in Luke 10:5-7. The Person of Peace offered hospitality, was receptive to the Gospel, and provided an entry point into their community.
- C. **Characteristics of a Person of Peace:**
1. **Receptivity:** They are spiritually open, willing to listen, and eager to learn.
 2. **Influence:** They hold a position of respect or have natural connections within the community.
 3. **Hospitality:** They demonstrate generosity, welcoming you into their home or network.

II. THE BIBLICAL BASIS FOR FINDING A PERSON OF PEACE

A. Jesus' Strategy:

1. In Luke 10:1-12, Jesus sent out 72 disciples to proclaim the Kingdom of God. He instructed them to look for receptive households—specifically, the Person of Peace who would welcome them and provide a base for ministry.

B. Examples in the Book of Acts:

1. **Cornelius (Acts 10):** Cornelius, a Roman centurion, was receptive to Peter's message, brought his entire household together, and helped spread the message to his social network.
2. **Lydia (Acts 16:13-15):** Lydia was a merchant of purple cloth in Philippi. She welcomed Paul and his companions into her home after believing, and her household became a center for new believers.

III. WHY START WITH A PERSON OF PEACE?

- A. **Eases Entry:** A Person of Peace opens doors, providing natural access to new relationships and helping you overcome cultural or social barriers.
- B. **Catalyzes Multiplication:** The Person of Peace can quickly spread the message through their existing network, enabling faster multiplication.
- C. **Reduces Resistance:** Instead of forcing entry into a new community, finding a Person of Peace leverages an already receptive heart, reducing friction and resistance.

IV. IDENTIFYING THE PERSON OF PEACE IN YOUR CONTEXT

A. Praying for Guidance

- 1. **Dependence on the Holy Spirit:** Begin with prayer, asking God to lead you to those who are spiritually open. It is the Holy Spirit who prepares hearts to receive the Gospel.
- 2. **Discernment and Listening:** Practice listening prayer, asking God for wisdom and insight into whom He is drawing near. Trust that God will highlight people who are ready.

B. Signs of a Person of Peace

- 1. **They Welcome You:** A Person of Peace is willing to spend time with you and is open to forming a relationship. They show interest in spiritual conversations.
- 2. **They Show Hospitality:** Just as Lydia invited Paul into her home, the Person of Peace might invite you for coffee, a meal, or to a social gathering.
- 3. **They Share Your Message with Others:** A key indicator of a Person of Peace is that they are willing to bring others into the conversation—friends, family, or neighbors. This shows they are open to using their influence for the Gospel.

C. Where to Look for a Person of Peace

- 1. **Everyday Places:** Coffee shops, community centers, workplaces, gyms, or parks—look for those who are willing to engage in conversation.
- 2. **Community Gatekeepers:** Identify key figures in the community, such as local business owners, leaders, or respected elders, who have influence and can open doors for you to connect with others.

3. **Personal Networks:** Begin with the relationships you already have. Who among your friends, family, or acquaintances might be spiritually open and connected to others?

D. **Practical Activity:**

1. **Prayer Walk:** Go on a prayer walk in your neighborhood or community. Pray for God to reveal People of Peace. Pay attention to those who show interest in speaking with you or offer to help in some way.

Exercise: Write down a list of people in your community or social circle who might be a Person of Peace. Start praying for each of them daily, asking God to reveal their openness.

V. **ENGAGING THE PERSON OF PEACE**

A. **Building Trust and Relationship**

1. **Spending Time Together:** The first step in engaging the Person of Peace is building a relationship. Take time to get to know them, listen to their story, and show genuine interest in their lives.

Exercise: Commit to spending time with a potential Person of Peace at least once a week—this could be through a shared activity, such as coffee, a walk, or helping them with a project.

2. **Service and Generosity:** Offer practical help. Acts of kindness build trust and demonstrate Christ's love in tangible ways.

Examples: Offer to help with yard work, babysit, or assist with an errand. Serving creates opportunities for deeper conversations.

B. **Introducing Spiritual Conversations**

1. **Start with Stories:** Share your personal testimony—what God has done in your life. People are more likely to connect with your personal story than abstract doctrines.

Exercise: Practice sharing a short version of your testimony with a friend. Aim for three minutes, focusing on who you were before Jesus, how you met Him, and what He has done in your life.

2. **Gauge Their Interest:** Look for signs of spiritual curiosity. Do they ask questions about your faith? Are they interested in learning more about Jesus or discussing

the Bible?

3. **Use Questions to Engage:** Ask open-ended questions like:
 - “What do you think about spirituality?”
 - “Have you ever had a spiritual experience that you can’t explain?”
 - These questions help gauge their interest and openness without being forceful.

VI. HOSTING A DISCOVERY BIBLE STUDY (DBS)

A. Once you’ve identified and engaged a Person of Peace, invite them to read and discuss the Bible with you. A Discovery Bible Study is an effective tool because it is simple, reproducible, and allows everyone to hear from God’s Word.

B. DBS Format:

1. **Read a Passage:** Choose a simple, relatable passage such as John 10:1-30 (Jesus never Loses Sheep).
2. **Ask Questions:**
 - “What does this teach us about God?”
 - “What does this teach us about people?”
 - “How should we respond to what we’ve learned?”
3. **Commitment:** Encourage them to share what they’ve learned with someone else in their network. They can also commit to simply returning for the next meeting or commit to seeking answers and asking questions.

Lesson 4 and Appendix “3/3 Group Series – Discover Series” will cover this further.

VII. USING THE PERSON OF PEACE AS A CATALYST FOR GROWTH

A. Enter Their Oikos

1. **What is an Oikos?:** “Oikos” is the Greek word for household or extended relational network. It includes family, friends, neighbors, coworkers—anyone with whom the Person of Peace has influence.
2. **Expanding Reach:** A Person of Peace naturally introduces you to their oikos. They might invite their family or friends to a meal, a Bible discussion, or a church event, providing opportunities for multiplication.

3. Cornelius gathered his household and friends to hear Peter speak (Acts 10:24). Through Cornelius, the message of Jesus spread to many others.

B. Empowering the Person of Peace

1. **Discipleship Before Conversion:** It's possible to begin discipling a Person of Peace before they fully commit to Jesus. As they grow in understanding, they often come to faith, along with members of their household.
2. **Training the Person of Peace:**
 - **Model and Teach:** Meet regularly with the Person of Peace to help them grow in their faith and knowledge of the Bible. Model how to lead a Discovery Bible Study, then assist them in leading, eventually allowing them to lead on their own.
 - **Encourage Sharing:** Equip the Person of Peace to share their testimony and lead Bible studies within their own network.
Exercise: Role-play leading a Discovery Bible Study with the Person of Peace, giving them practical feedback and encouragement.

C. Hosting Simple Church Gatherings

1. **Meeting in Their Home:** A Person of Peace's home often becomes the base for gathering a small group. The first church meetings in the New Testament took place in homes, and this model is still effective today.

D. Releasing the Person of Peace

1. **Empowering Them to Lead:** Once the Person of Peace has demonstrated an ability to lead, step back and let them lead their own group. Encourage them to find other People of Peace within their network and repeat the process.

VIII. PRACTICAL EXERCISES FOR FINDING AND ENGAGING A PERSON OF PEACE

A. Community Mapping:

1. **Create a Map:** Draw a map of your community, including key places—coffee shops, community centers, and neighborhoods. Mark areas where you have connections or have identified possible People of Peace.

2. **Identify Hotspots:** Highlight places where People of Peace are likely to be found, such as where community leaders gather or places of high social activity.
3. **Prayer Focus:** Pray over each area of your map daily, asking God to lead you to the right individuals. Prayer walk the areas weekly or bi-weekly.

B. Weekly Outreach Goals:

1. Set a weekly goal to engage with at least two people whom you think might be a Person of Peace. Track these interactions in a journal.
2. **Questions to Consider:**
 - Did they show hospitality?
 - Were they interested in spiritual discussions?
 - Did they express a desire to meet again or introduce you to others?

IX. A CALL TO ACTION

Make it a priority to actively seek out People of Peace in your daily life. Pray consistently for guidance, be intentional in building relationships, and be bold in sharing your story. Engaging even one Person of Peace can transform an entire community.

This lesson was provided by Joshua Nations (JoshuaNations.org).